REGIONALISM AND INTEGRATION IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

Regionalism definitely pertains to a particular region. There have been untiring efforts on the part of the scholars to define a region. Prof. Palmer and Perkins[2] tried to emphasize that in international relations "a region is invariably an area embracing the territories of three or more states. These states are bound together by ties of common interests as well as geography. They are not necessarily contiguous, or even in the same continent". There are no hard and fast rules to determine what is meant by the term regions. Regions are often constituted by countries sharing common bond of race, institutions and political interests. When these states come together and form an organizational association at the regional level to attain specific objectives, regional arrangements are born. What is important is that, most often, the states joining such regional organizations need not belong to the same geographic region or area. The factor, which reinforces such forging of bond, is perceived as "common interests".

At the San Francisco Conference of 1945, the Egyptian delegation introduced an amendment to the draft text of the United Nations Charter where they limited the term 'regional arrangements' by definition, to "organizations of a permanent nature grouping in a given geographical area several countries which, by reason of their proximity, community of interest or cultural, linguistic, historical, or spiritual affinities, make themselves jointly responsible for the peaceful settlement of any disputes which may arise between them for the maintenance of peace and security in their regions, as well as safeguarding of their national interests and the development of their economic and cultural relations".[3] According to Dr. E.N. Van Kleffens, "…regional arrangement or pact is a voluntary association of sovereign states within a certain area or having common interests in that area for a joint purpose, which should not be of an offensive nature, in relation to that area".[4]

Before discussing about some of the prominent regional arrangements that exist today, it will be worthwhile to take a look at